

and go; but authenticity always sticks around," says Rakshay Dhariwal, Founder and Managing Director of Pass Code Hospitality.

A similar philosophy is taking shape elsewhere in the country. Hidden behind a bookshelf inside Hyderabad's 130-year-old heritage Country Club, Oxymorons is about finding harmony between things that seem opposite: old and new, local and global, familiar and unexpected. "The hidden door is just the beginning of the story, not the story itself," claims founder Rehan Guha.

Meanwhile, Goa's After Dinner, a 30-seater tucked away within Pisco by the Beach, moves away from the coastal state's bustling beach club culture. "We wanted the space to feel like going over to a friend's place for a few drinks after dinner," says founder Twinkle Keswani and adds, "with Pisco by the Beach being a larger-format space, After Dinner was our chance to explore the other end of the spectrum and create something more intimate. One of the nicest things to see is people walking in as separate groups and leaving as friends."

The luxury of less

Step into many of India's newest cocktail destinations and one thing becomes immediately apparent: they are getting smaller. Increasingly, they are also bars inside bigger bars, usually in reservation-only format, offering guests a completely different experience than what is offered in the larger place.

The Director's Room at PCO seats just 12 guests. Theatre, tucked within ZLB23 at The Leela Palace Bengaluru, welcomes only seven at a time. The Hidden Club inside Olive Bar & Kitchen, New Delhi, accommodates four, while the capital's other popular speakeasy, Cavity at Barbet & Pals, is a nine-seater.

According to AD Singh, Founder and Managing Director of Olive Group, luxury today is no longer defined by size but by thoughtfully, curated experiences. "Guests today want a story, a connection, and something that feels a little special, and we are seeing a growing interest in such experiences that feel more personal and intimate rather than just another night out," he says.

Theatre in Bengaluru too embodies this spirit, with the sound, lighting and presentation coming together in an audio-visual experience designed to immerse guests from start to finish. According to Nishant Agarwal, Vice President and General Manager, The Leela Palace Bengaluru, today's drinkers are looking for "visually appealing presentations and memorable experiences," where storytelling becomes as important as flavour.

